

## Chapter-2

# MODALS

1. A Modal is an auxiliary verb (generally termed a *helping verb*) which is used with a main verb to indicate a particular attitude such as *possibility, obligation, prediction*, etc. e.g. can, could, may, might, will, would, shall, should, must, ought to, dare, need, used to. Modals are also sometimes referred to as *Modal verbs* or *Modal Auxiliaries*.
2. Auxiliaries in English are of two types:

(a)

|             |                                     |
|-------------|-------------------------------------|
| <u>Be</u>   | is, am, are, was, were, being, been |
| <u>Have</u> | has, have, had                      |
| <u>Do</u>   | do, does, did                       |

These help to form *Tenses, Interrogatives* and *Negatives*. Many a time they act as *Main verbs* also.

**Example :** (i) **As Main Verbs:**

The book *is* on the table.

We *are* brothers.

I *have* a pen.

I *do* my duty.

She has a book.

I had two balls.

**Example :** (ii) **As Helping Verbs:**

She *is* playing a match.

I *am* not writing a letter.

I *did* not hit him.

An apple *was* eaten by Sita.

Are the boys *being* punished by the teacher?

*Has* this picture been seen by you?

(b) **Modal Auxiliaries or Modals :**

- Modal Auxiliaries (or Modals) *cannot be used as main verbs* or as independent Primary Auxiliaries.

- Modals *are never used alone*. They are used to help a main (principal) verb.
- They *do not* have the infinitive, Present Participle or Past Participle forms.
- They cannot be used in all tenses.

Modals are mainly used to indicate one's attitude towards what one is saying or when one is concerned about the effect of one's speech on the other person in the communication channels.

- Modals have a special use in 3 types of complex sentences.
- Modals are followed by the base *form* of a verb.

I must *leave* now.

It will *be* nice to say so.

You ought to *pay* the taxes.

- When a modal is followed by 'be' + *Present Participle*, this indicates that one is talking about the *Present* or *Future*, e.g.

He *may be* watching.

The play *will be* starting soon.

- But when a modal is followed by have + Past Participle, this indicates that one is talking about the past e.g.

You *must have* noticed his behaviour.

She *may have* left already.

I *ought to have* replied.

- In passive sentences, the pattern is:

|           |           |                              |
|-----------|-----------|------------------------------|
| (modal) + | + be      | + (Past Participle)          |
|           | have been | 3 <sup>rd</sup> form of verb |

**Examples :** His statement *will be published* soon.

You *can be arrested* any time now.

Such changes may *have been justified*.

- A modal is never followed by the auxiliary verb 'do' or any other modal.
- Modals do not inflect. They do not have any- 's' form, 'ing' or '-ed' forms.

### 3. The use of Modals

#### 1. Use of 'WILL'

**'Will' is used :**

- (i) to refer to or express Simple Future in the sense of *Prediction*:

1. It will rain tomorrow.

(*I predict so*)

2. You will go to school.

(*Simple Future*)

### Important Notes:

- (a) In Declarative sentences, with I/We as subjects, the use of shall and will is interchangeable.
- (b) Will/shall are not used in clauses beginning with 'if', 'when':  
If I go to Mumbai, I'll bring a camera for you.  
If it rains heavily, we 'll float paper boats.  
When he comes, we shall begin the work.
- (ii) to express *willingness/intention/wish*:  
I will lend you some money. (*I am willing to do so*)  
Who will go home? (*Who is willing to?*)
- (iii) to express a *request/invitation or order* in yes/no question with 'you' as a subject:  
Will you accompany me home? (*I request you to do so*)  
Will you shut up? (*I order you so*)  
Will you like to have a cup of tea? (*Invitation*)
- (iv) to express *general facts*:  
Oil will float on water. (*Oil floats on water*)  
Pigs will eat anything. (*Pigs eat anything*)
- (v) to express a *characteristic habit*:  
She'll sit there for hours doing nothing. (*habit*)  
He will tell you anything. (*habit*)
- (vi) to express *threat or promise* or a single impersonal *command*:  
I will teach him a lesson. (*threat*)  
I will try to improve next time. (*promise*)  
You will not attend my class. (*command*)

## 2. USE OF 'SHALL'

### 'Shall' is used:

- (i) to express simple future or a prediction in the same way as 'will'.
- (ii) to express suggestion (in yes/no question with 'we' as subject) :  
Shall we start the game? (*I suggest we start*)  
Shall we play cards? (*let us.....*)
- (iii) volition/will of the listener :  
(In yes/no question with 'I' as subject)  
Shall I come tomorrow? (*Do you want me to come?*)  
Shall I make some tea for you? (*Do you want so?*)
- (iv) to express willingness, intention or insistence on the part of the speaker:  
He *shall* go. (*I insist on his going*)

He *will* go. (He insists on his going)

He *shall* be rewarded if he remains patient. (I'll do that)

(v) in Declarative sentences :

Jack *will* do it. (Simple Future)

Jack *shall* do it. (I'll see to it that Jack does it)

You *will* not betray my trust. (You'll have to go)

He *shall* not betray my trust. (determination/order)

### 3. USE OF 'WOULD'

#### 'Would' is used:

(i) to express future in the past (as in Reported Speech):

She *told* me that he *would* go.

He *said* that you *would* tell a lie.

(ii) to express *willingness, intention* or *determination* or probability:

I *would* do that for you. (I am willing- If you ask me)

He *would* be at home now. (probability)

I *would* go out for a long walk. (intention)

I *would* give up smoking. (determination)

*Note : 'Would' here indicates more tentativeness than 'will'*

(iii) to express a habitual activity:

She *would sit* here for hours, saying prayers. (would in this sense = used to)

He *would* take a long walk after meals every day.

(iv) to express a *wish* :

I wish he *would* stand first.

I wish there *would* be no rumour.

*Would* that I were rich!

(v) to express a *desire/make a request*:

I *would* like to have a glass of water.

*Would* you say something on the subject? (request)

(vi) to express as unreal *condition*:

Had you worked hard, you *would* have passed.

If I had reached there in time, I *would* have caught the train.

(vii) to express a preference:

I *would* rather die than beg.

I *would* like to stay with her today. (= I like to stay)

#### 4. USE OF 'SHOULD'

##### 'Should' is used:

- (i) to express *duty/necessity/obligation*:

(i) You *should* serve your country.

(ii) We *should* help the poor.

(iii) You *should* take exercise daily.

- (ii) to express tentative use (meaning 'in case') :

*Should* you come early, you can see me in my room.

(*I know you won't but in case you do*)

*Should* he give up drinking, he can hope to win her over.

(*I know he won't but in case he does*)

- (iii) to express *purpose or suggestion or condition*:

Walk fast lest you *should* miss the train.

(*purpose*)

You *should* not leave this place so late in the night.

(*suggestion*)

I *should* be glad to meet him.

(*condition*)

#### 5. USE OF 'CAN'

##### 'Can' is used:

- (i) to express *ability*:

He *can* lift this heavy load.

She *can* drive a car.

- (ii) to refer to a characteristic (only a sporadic pattern of behaviour, usually in a derogatory sense):

She *can* be cunning at times.

(*it is her nature*)

Raghu *can* tell awful lies.

(*Characteristic*)

- (iii) to make a *request*:

*Can* I use your pen, please?

*Can* you pass on the salt, sir?

- (iv) to express permission:

You *can* go home now.

He *can* make his own choice.

- (v) to express *possibility*:

She *can* be hiding.

He *can* come today.

- (vi) with *verbs of sensation (empty use)*:

I *can* see the moon.

(= *I see the moon*)

I *can* hear music.

(= *I hear music*)

## 6. USE OF 'COULD'

### 'Could' is used:

- (i) as a *Past Tense* of can:

I told him that he *could* take the test.

She said that she *could* do that.

- (ii) to express ability (past time):

He could lift that heavy load.

(*He had the capability to*)

**Important Note :** In this sense *could* is never used to refer to a single successful achievement : e.g.

He ran fast and was able to catch the bus (not 'he ran fast and could catch the bus').

- (iii) to express a *characteristic* (past time):

She *could* be very unkind.

(*It was her nature*)

He *could* be cunning.

- (iv) to make a *request*:

*Could* you give me a glass of water, please?

**Important Notes :** 'Could' in such cases shows more politeness than 'can'.

- (v) to request for permission:

*Could* I take her out, mother?

**Important Notes:** 'Could' is more polite than 'can'.

- (vi) With *verbs of sensation*:

I *could* hear music.

(*I heard music*)

### Other Examples :

You *could* have helped him.

He *could* not help laughing.

## 7. USE OF 'OUGHT TO'

### 'Ought to' is used:

- (i) to express *duty/necessity/obligation* in the same way as *should*.

I *ought* to go now.

You *ought* to take medicine regularly.

We *ought* to serve your country.

### Important Notes :

1. *Ought to* is not as forceful as *must*.  
He *ought* to go but he won't. We can't say : He *must* go but he won't.
2. The Past Tense of *ought to* is expressed with *ought to have* + 3rd form of the verb.  
He *ought to have* attended the meeting.  
She *ought to have* helped you.

## 8. USE OF 'MUST'

### 'Must' is used:

- (i) to express *compulsion, obligation, necessity, duty, advice*:
  - You *must* attend the class. (compulsion)
  - We *must* respect our elders. (obligation)
  - You *must* serve your country. (duty)
  - A subordinate *must* obey his boss. (necessity)
  - You *must* wear a helmet. (advice)
  - You *must* not waste your time. (advice)
- (ii) to express a *determination*:
  - I *must* top the list this time.
  - I *must* get a seat this time.
- (iii) to express a *logical necessity or expectation*:
  - You must feel sorry for the mess you have made.
  - He must have played foul somewhere.
  - He must be mad to do it. (Past = must have)
- (iv) to express a *possibility*:
  - She *must* have reached Mumbai by now.

## 9. USE OF 'MAY'

### 'May' is used:

- (i) to express *permission* ( or seek permission):
  - You may leave now. (I permit you to leave)
  - May I come in, sir ? (Am I permitted to come in?)
- (ii) to express *benediction* (or rarely *malediction*):
  - May you go up in life!
  - May he live long!
  - May he be burnt alive! (I curse him)
- (iii) to express *possibility*:
  - Sita may turn up any moment now. (it is possible that)
  - She may be there now. (possibility)

**Important Note :** The past form in such case would be *may have*, e.g.

Sita *may have* turned up last week.

- (iv) to express a *purpose*:
  - He is building his body so that he *may* join army.
  - He is working hard so that he *may* pass with good marks.

### Important Notes:

1. In the sense of *permission*, 'can' and 'may' are interchangeable, though *may* is more formal.
2. In declarative sentences, *can* and *may* are interchangeable, in the sense of possibility, e.g.

He may be hiding.

He can be hiding.

Both *these sentences* have the *same meaning*. But in question it is not so. We can say:

Can he be hiding?

But we cannot say:

May he be hiding?

## 10. USE OF 'MIGHT'

### 'Might' is used:

- (i) to express the Past Tense of 'May':

He *thought he might* play a useful role.

He *asked* her if he *might* take the test.

He *told* me that he *might* join the party.

- (ii) to express permission (or seek permission):

*Might* I come in, sir?

- (iii) to express a *remote possibility* (Present time):

He *might* be there now.

(It is possible)

It *might* rain today.

He *might* win a lottery.

**Note :** 'Might' here shows greater tentativeness or uncertainty than 'May'.

## 11. USE OF 'USED TO'

### 'Used to' is used:

- (i) to express *a habit in the past*:

(Note : It does not have a Present Tense form).

He *used to* go out for a walk every morning.

As a child, she *used to* love dolls.

I am not *used to* such treatment.

I am *used to* hard work.

## 12. USE OF 'DARE'

- (i) Dare is used to express 'courage' or 'venture':

He *dare* not oppose me.

How *dare* you insult me ?

He *dare* not face me.

### Important Notes:

1. The positive form of *dare* does not function as auxiliary in declarative sentences in the main clause.

We can say:

I daren't do it.

He needn't go.

Dare you do it?

Nee he go?

But *we cannot say*:

I dare do it.

He need go.

2. The Past Tense form corresponding to *dare* is *daren't have + 3rd form of verb*.
3. *Dare* is used as a *regular verb in all tenses* with 'to' in order to express *courage/challenge*.

She *does not dare* to offend you.

He *dared me* to a duel.

### 13. USE OF 'NEED'

#### 'Need' is used :

- (i) *Need* is used to express *necessity/obligation*:

(Used in Present Tense)

He *need* not go there again.

She *need* not worry for her test.

*Needn't* you go there at all?

*Need* I stay there?

No, you *needn't*.

### Important Notes:

1. 'Need' questions generally get a negative answer.
2. As Past Tense, *need* is expressed with *need + have + 3rd form of the verb*.  
You *needn't* have done it.  
She *needn't* have used unfair means.
3. *Needn't* expresses absence of obligation. It can be used in questions as well as statements.
4. *Need* is used as main verb to express requirement.

He *needs* some money.

He doesn't *need* punishment, he *needs* help.

## Exercises for Practice

### Exercise 1

Fill in the blanks with will/shall/need/must/used to:

1. My grandmother ..... go for a morning walk every day in her youth.
2. You ..... keep your promises.
3. He ..... not go to the market. I have already brought the vegetables.
4. I ..... lend you my pen if you give me your notebook.
5. You ..... get a prize if you finish your work in time.

### Exercise 2

Study the solved examples given below and use 'can'/'cannot' in the sentences you frame:

List 5 things you can do.

List 5 things you cannot do

*Example:* 1. I can drive a car.

1. I cannot fly a plane.

2. ....

2. ....

3. ....

3. ....

4. ....

4. ....

5. ....

5. ....

6. ....

6. ....

### Exercise 3

Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :

- |                                                         |                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| 1. .... you do me a favour?                             | (Will/May)      |
| 2. We ..... buy any sugar. There's enough in the house. | (need not/must) |
| 3. The rich ..... help the poor.                        | (should/must)   |
| 4. The breeze is cold and fresh. It ..... rain soon.    | (may/might)     |
| 5. She ..... speak English when she was hardly four.    | (could/can)     |
| 6. He ..... have stolen your pen.                       | (may/can)       |
| 7. I am afraid the news ..... be true.                  | (may/might)     |
| 8. She ..... not disobey her husband.                   | (can/should)    |
| 9. How ..... you ride a bicycle without brakes?         | (can/will)      |
| 10. .... I have a holiday?                              | (can/need)      |

## **Exercise 4**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. .... I open the windows?
2. .... we play in the garden?
3. They ..... to work hard for a living.
4. You ..... take exercise daily.
5. .... God bless you!
6. He ..... be mad to do this. (must/should)
7. We ..... to help the poor people.
8. We ..... not spit on the floor.
9. We ..... not waste time in idle gossips.
10. .... you please stop talking?

## **Exercise 5**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. You ..... take exercise daily. (should/must)
2. You ..... keep your promise. (must/may)
3. We ..... not to walk on the grass. (ought/should)
4. Take heed lest you ..... fall. (must/should)
5. Do you think she ..... apologize? (will/can)
6. I ..... like to see that book. (would/will)
7. We ..... love our neighbour. (should/can)
8. You ..... come to school in time. (should/may)
9. You ..... see a doctor at once. (must/will)
10. I ..... come if it rains. (shall/should)

## **Exercise 6**

**Choose the correct Modals from the brackets and fill in the blanks :**

1. .... you bet hundred rupees? (will/shall)
2. The police ..... find out the culprit. (will/shall)
3. A judge ..... be upright. (must/ought)
4. Students ..... to maintain discipline. (must/ought)
5. India ..... not win this match. (can/may)
6. The girl ..... or ..... not dance. (can/may)

## **Exercise 7**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. .... you please stop talking?
2. You ..... go home whenever you like.
3. It ..... rain, it is so sultry.
4. One ..... always be kind to others.
5. If you have a ticket, you ..... go inside.
6. Your father is sleeping, you ..... not speak loudly.
7. I ..... visit my sister tomorrow.

## **Exercise 8**

**Complete the following conversation by supplying suitable Modals in the blanks :**

- Gita : ..... you help me with some money?  
Sita : How much do you need?  
Gita : I ..... do with just two hundred rupees.  
Sita : ..... it be fine if I give you a cheque?  
Gita : ..... I get it encashed today?  
Sita : Why not? But you ..... go to the bank soon as it is already 12:30. The bank ..... close at 1 p.m today.  
Gita : Please write the cheque at once. I ..... rush to the bank just now.

## **Exercise 9**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. He said that it ..... be true. (may/might)
2. He ..... enter the college next year. (would/must)
3. Sita ..... win the first prize in English.
4. .... you live long to enjoy it!
5. I ..... speak English.
6. Even as a child she ..... sing well.
7. .... you come to the meeting tomorrow?
8. We ..... not tell lies.

## **Exercise 10**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. You ..... clean your teeth every morning.
2. .... you finish this work in two hours?
3. It ..... rain today. (very little possibility)

4. This box is very heavy, I ..... not lift it.
5. .... his soul rest in peace!
6. You ..... take a taxi or you will miss the train.
7. The doctor says that I ..... eat anything I like.
8. .... you like to read this book ?
9. Walk carefully lest you ..... sprain your foot.
10. .... you lift this elephant?

### **Exercise 11**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. We ..... hurry. We are very late. (may/might)
2. I am afraid I ..... tell you that it is a secret. (may/shall not)
3. Children ..... to obey their parents. (can, could, may, might, ought)
4. .... I borrow your pen for a minute? (must, may, will, should)
5. We ..... to live like brothers. (could, should, ought, might)
6. I ..... type eighty words in a minute. (may, can, could, should)
7. It ..... rain today. (could, might)
8. He ..... not go home now, he thought. (can, could)
9. He ..... not insult me. (dare, must)
10. He ..... play cricket in his childhood. (used to/could)

### **Exercise 12**

**Complete the following dialogue by filling in the blanks with suitable Modals :**

- Hafiz : Sadaf, when ..... you come to my place?
- Sadaf : Not before five in the evening.
- Hafiz : At what time ..... we leave for the theatre then?
- Sadaf : There's plenty of time. Dont' worry. We ..... reach on time.
- Hafiz : I am quite worried. Anything ..... happen to the car and we ..... have to miss the show.
- Sadaf : ..... you please stop worrying for nothing?

### **Exercise 13**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

1. You ..... have your prize tomorrow. (promise)
2. I ..... do or die.
3. I ..... lend you some money.
4. We decided that we ..... not go any farther.

5. He said that you ..... be absent.
6. I ..... help him with money before I leave for London.
7. I ..... try to do better next time.
8. You ..... do your home work regularly.
9. You ..... have a holiday tomorrow.
10. .... I help you?

### **Exercise 14**

**Fill in the blanks with may, might, can, could :**

1. I ..... solve the sums.
2. There ..... be some flaw in their way of working.
3. .... you live long!
4. It ..... rain today.
5. .... I come in, sir?
6. .... you die by inches!
7. I ..... speak English when I was only five.
8. He worked hard so that he ..... stand first.
9. You ..... come to school in time.
10. You ..... laugh at her mistakes.

### **Exercise 15**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

- |                                                 |                |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| 1. I ..... rather die than beg.                 | (will/would)   |
| 2. Now let me see, ..... you read this name?    | (can/will)     |
| 3. You ..... see it happen gradually!           | (will/would)   |
| 4. He ..... not be pacified in any way.         | (could/should) |
| 5. You ..... hear the music.                    | (can/might)    |
| 6. Hamlet promised that he ..... do that.       | (will/would)   |
| 7. He finds reasons why he ..... not do so yet. | (should/would) |
| 8. You ..... not go on wasting your time.       | (may/should)   |
| 9. You ..... never make that mistake again.     | (should/must)  |
| 10. He says that he ..... never pay the money.  | (will/should)  |

## **Exercise 16**

**Fill in the blanks with appropriate Modals :**

- |                                                    |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| 1. I ..... beat him.                               | (could/might)      |
| 2. I thought I ..... win.                          | (will/would)       |
| 3. He ..... play into my hands.                    | (shall/should)     |
| 4. I felt I ..... win by only a few inches.        | (could/may)        |
| 5. They ..... all be waiting at the next stop.     | (can/will)         |
| 6. They ..... stoop so low, he said.               | (cannot/would not) |
| 7. A gentleman ..... be fair to all.               | (will/shall)       |
| 8. You ..... have the last laugh.                  | (might/must)       |
| 9. I am afraid you ..... have to go.               | (may/will)         |
| 10. He did not know what he ..... do with himself. | (shall/should)     |